Salma L. Naga-Marohombsar

Dr. Salma L. Naga-Marohombsar is a Filipino mathematician, educator, and institutional leader from the Bangsamoro region of Mindanao, recognized as one of the most consequential figures in the academic life of the Mindanao State University (MSU) system.

She holds a PhD in Mathematics and has been a faculty member of the Mathematics Department at MSU Marawi since 1999, when she became the first Muslim woman to join that department, a milestone that opened doors for generations of Bangsamoro women in STEM. She is currently the Chairperson of the Mathematics Department (2023 to present).

Her career brings together three threads that rarely converge in a single person: rigorous mathematical research, deeply rooted community service, and fearless academic leadership.

When the 2017 Marawi Siege displaced thousands and shuttered the university, Dr. Naga-Marohombsar didn't step back. She stepped forward, leading the campaign that brought students home to campus before the conflict had even fully ended.

Her legacy is built on firsts and on the willingness to keep showing up, whether in the classroom, the boardroom, the badminton court, or a peace consultation table.

Dr. Salma L. Naga-Marohombsar



Known for	First Muslimah faculty member, MSU Main Mathematics Department; leader of the Balik MSU campaign during the 2017 Marawi Siege
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranaw
Degree	PhD in Mathematics
Institution	Mindanao State University (MSU) Marawi
Department	College of Natural Sciences and Mathematics (CNSM)
Current role	Chairperson, Mathematics Department (2023 to present)
Faculty since	1999
Research venues	*Ars Combinatoria*; *Advances and Applications in Discrete Mathematics*

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Background

Dr. Naga-Marohombsar belongs to the Bangsamoro community and has built her life's work within and alongside the people of Marawi City and the broader Bangsamoro region of Mindanao.

Her identity as a Bangsamoro woman in mathematics is not incidental to her career. It's central to it.

From the very beginning, she entered spaces where women like her were not yet represented, and she stayed, grew, and eventually led those same spaces.

Her commitment to education as a vehicle for community uplift has been the consistent thread running through her academic, administrative, and advocacy work across more than two decades.

Education

Dr. Naga-Marohombsar holds a Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) in Mathematics, a credential that anchors her scholarly contributions in one of the most demanding disciplines in higher education.

The source document does not specify the institution where she completed her doctoral studies, but her academic career has been centered within the MSU system, where she has taught, researched, and led since 1999.

Her doctoral formation shaped both her research output and her approach to institutional development, allowing her to contribute meaningfully to curriculum, policy, and graduate studies frameworks at the university level.

Career

Dr. Naga-Marohombsar joined the Mathematics Department of Mindanao State University Marawi in 1999 as its first Muslim woman faculty member, a distinction that was historic at the time and remains part of her enduring identity within the institution.

Over the course of more than two decades, she has grown from faculty member to one of the most broadly experienced academic administrators in the College of Natural Sciences and Mathematics (CNSM).

She is the only CNSM faculty member to have served as Chairperson of two distinct departments within the college: the Mathematics Department and the Graduate Studies Department.

As Chairperson of the Mathematics Department, she served her first term from 2012 to 2013 and is currently in her second term, which began in 2023.

She also served as Chairperson of the Graduate Studies Department from 2019 to 2022, a role that ended when the department was dissolved.

Beyond department leadership, she has held advisory roles at the highest levels of the MSU system, serving as Special Assistant to the Vice President for Academic Affairs and as Special Assistant to the Vice Chancellor for Research and Extension.

These appointments reflect the breadth of trust the institution has placed in her across academic, research, and policy domains.

Leadership During Crisis and Peace Advocacy

Perhaps the most defining chapter of Dr. Naga-Marohombsar's career came in the aftermath of the 2017 Marawi Siege, when the city was devastated by months of armed conflict and MSU Marawi was left empty and uncertain.

As the Over-all Team Leader of the **Balik MSU: Somombak Tano sa Pantaw a Mareg** campaign, she led the critical effort to bring students back to campus even before the siege had fully concluded.

The campaign's name, which translates roughly to "Return to MSU: Let Us Go Back to the Shore of the Lake," carries with it the spirit of belonging, resilience, and homecoming that defined the initiative.

In a time when many institutions would have waited for clearer skies, Dr. Naga-Marohombsar and her team made a deliberate choice to treat education itself as an act of peace and recovery.

Her advocacy for peace doesn't stop at the campus gates. She has served as a consultant for the **Principles for Peace Key Sectoral Consultations**, contributing her perspective and expertise to broader conversations about peacebuilding in Mindanao.

She also served as the **Marawi Area Focal Person** for the **Mindanao Young Women Leaders Forum**, a platform dedicated to amplifying the voices of young Bangsamoro women in peace and development work.

On the international stage, she has presented on the topic **Science + Peace: What's Math Got to Do with It?**, a talk that bridges her academic discipline with her deep commitment to building a more just and peaceful society.

This question, what mathematics has to do with peace, is one that speaks to who she is: a scientist who sees her field not in isolation, but in conversation with the world around it.

Institutional Contributions

Dr. Naga-Marohombsar has left lasting marks on the policy and governance infrastructure of the MSU system.

She contributed to the crafting of the **MSU Graduate Studies Handbook**, a document that shapes how graduate education is structured and delivered across the MSU system.

She also contributed to the **Evaluation Guidelines for MSU Chancellors**, a framework that governs one of the most consequential leadership positions in the university system.

These contributions place her among the small circle of faculty members who have helped define not just the culture of the university, but its formal rules and standards.

Her dual role as both a practitioner (teaching, researching, leading departments) and a policy architect gives her contributions a durability that extends well beyond any single term or position.

Research Excellence

As a mathematician, Dr. Naga-Marohombsar has produced scholarly work that has earned international recognition and placement in high-quality academic venues.

Her research has been published in ISI and Scopus-indexed journals, including **Ars Combinatoria** and **Advances and Applications in Discrete Mathematics**, two respected venues in the field of discrete mathematics and combinatorics.

This publication record places her among a relatively small group of MSU faculty whose research meets the standards of international peer review and indexing.

In 2020, her contributions to scholarship were formally recognized when she was named **Distinguished Faculty Member in the Field of Research** by the university.

Her research profile also made her a qualifier for the prestigious **CHED Republica Award**, a national recognition that reflects the quality and impact of her scholarly output.

University Life and Sports

Academic excellence and institutional leadership aside, Dr. Naga-Marohombsar is also a celebrated figure in university sports.

She is actively engaged as a coordinator, coach, and champion in **women's badminton** for the university, a dimension of her campus life that speaks to her all-around presence and energy within the MSU community.

Her involvement in sports reflects the same spirit that defines her broader career: full commitment, genuine participation, and a will to win.

Legacy

Dr. Naga-Marohombsar's legacy in the MSU system is built on a rare combination of academic depth, institutional courage, and community rootedness.

She is remembered as the woman who broke the gender barrier in the MSU Marawi Mathematics Department in 1999, and as the leader who chose to bring students home during one of the most difficult moments in Marawi's history.

Her work proves that a mathematician can also be a peacebuilder, that a department chair can also be a badminton champion, and that a Bangsamoro woman can lead in every room she enters.

For young women in the Bangsamoro region considering careers in STEM and public service, Dr. Naga-Marohombsar is not just a role model. She is proof of what is possible.

Her story continues to be written, with her second term as Mathematics Department Chairperson (2023 to present) adding yet another chapter to a career that has never stopped moving forward.

Recognition

- **Distinguished Faculty Member in the Field of Research** (2020), Mindanao State University Marawi
- Qualifier, **CHED Republica Award** (Commission on Higher Education), for research excellence
- First Muslim woman faculty member, Mathematics Department, MSU Marawi (1999)
- Only CNSM faculty member to have served as Chairperson of two distinct departments

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- 2017 Marawi Siege
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- BangsamoroPedia
- Muslim women in STEM

External Links

- BangsamoroPedia: wiki.maranaw.com (https://wiki.maranaw.com)
- Mindanao State University Marawi Official Website (https://www.msumarawi.edu.ph)

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